traffic cops for the whole of Goa and no proper vehicle to patrol in for her. The capital Panjim, the busy market centre Margao; the busy port area that also housed the airport, Vasco da Gama; and yet another business centre, Mapusa. Each of these centres faced serious traffic problems and remained unattended for want of resources and leadership.

Right through her National Cadet Corps (NCC) days in college, Kiran had been very fond of her uniform. And in Goa she found that the depleted force at her command was used to working without a uniform. The reason was simple. The people of Goa did not respect them enough for, being so few in number, they couldn't do much. Hence, it was almost a case of having given up. Without any 'visible' demonstration of traffic control, the roads were free-for-all highways where fatality and congestion were commonplace. The sparse force found it safer to remain invisible.

The very first meeting she called of the Goa traffic police could very well have been a cameo from one of the run-of-the-mill Hindi movies: Belts slipping beneath paunchy waistlines, shoes like they'd been fished out of the sea and dirty uniforms and headgear crying out for replacement. Twenty-five such men standing in a group not just reeking of Fenny (a very potent and popular Goan brew made out of coconut or cashewnut juice) but also demonstrating its aftereffects, and looking with awe at the trim and immaculately uniformed officer addressing them.

'As it is I am allergic to strong perfumes, and this "aroma" was almost making me nauseous,' recalls Kiran, with an 'ugh'.

She explained to her men (as always no women) the benefits of becoming 'visible'. They should be proud of their uniform, she told them, and should wear it with pride and dignity. They had not opted for this job to lurk around in streets in civvies like discards of society. They had joined this profession to come forth and help the administration to sort out the problems of society, and, more importantly, to be seen to be doing so. The lecture was long and sincere and to the point and ended with her requesting them not to carry the tell-tale signs of Fenny with them, at least while they were on duty as one could sniff it from far. She emphasized that she was there to reward them and not punish them. All of them had heard of her sterling leadership qualities. The knew of her achievements as the head of the Delhi traffic police and also knew that she had declined to accept awards for herself alone. They all saw an opportunity for improving their performance with Kiran at the helm.

Inspired by the new leader, the traffic squad became a rejuvenated force. For the first time in years, the Goans saw traffic police in uniform constantly on the roads and actually helping in disentangling the snarls that were the order of the day for Goa traffic. The gesture was sincere and executed earnestly and the community responded positively. They let the SP (Traffic) know verbally and through letters that they appreciated her sincerity of purpose and that they would do their best to cooperate with her. Meetings were held regularly with different groups of the community to identify their problems and involve them in their solution. Several new features were introduced, such as clearance drives, systematization of traffic flow, community interaction with market and institutional associations, open-house meetings, prosecutions and educational and awareness programmes in collaboration with the Rotary Club and other citizens' groups.

The Goa Traffic Department soon developed into a no-nonsense, highly effective force. The rapid movement by policemen on motorcycles all over the place soon put fear into the hearts of the erring motorists who promptly started referring to them as 'hell's angels'. Over 3000 traffic cases were registered within a period of six months.

Even while the community was appreciating and responding to these new measures wholeheartedly, the administration revealed its 'greater-than-thou' attitude. A report was received at the traffic control room that the footpath below the State Secretariat was being used as a car park for